Paired Technical Interview Overview

Mock interviews are one of the most effective ways to prepare for technical interviews. They help you practice solving problems under realistic time pressure while also developing the technical communication skills required in a real interview setting. In addition, you'll gain experience evaluating a candidate's performance from the interviewer's perspective, which will help you understand how hiring decisions are made.

You will work in pairs, either with a partner you choose or one assigned to you if needed. Each pair will consist of one interviewer, and one candidate.

Interviewer

As the interviewer, your job is to run the interview, make a hiring decision, and CRUSH DREAMS �� (earnestly evaluate performance.)

You will:

- Introduce and explain the problem clearly
- Read the question prompt and clarify requirements
- Discuss edge cases and constraints
- Provide hints when appropriate (without giving away the solution)
- Answer the candidate's questions
- Write and submit
    - Structured notes taken during the interview
    - A short evaluation of performance, and a hiring decision

Your evaluation should include:

- Key strengths
- Key weaknesses
- A hiring recommendation

You will be graded on the quality of your notes and analysis, not on correctness of hints. Your comments and report will **not in any way** impact your partner's grade.

Interviewer Advice

- **Guide, don't solve:** Your job is to help them think, not lead them directly to the answer. Start with questions before giving hints.

- **Follow thinking:** If you can't follow their thinking, ask them questions: *"What are you thinking?"* or *"Can you walk me through your approach."*
- **Use progressive hints:** If they need hints, start with broad questions, then give small nudges only if needed. Avoid jumping straight to the key idea. ● **Look for positive signals, not perfection:** Focus on how they reason, adapt, and communicate. Getting the optimal solution is ideal, but not required if their communication and reasoning is strong.
- ***You will be partially graded on your notes in each section*:** Good evaluations use concrete examples (e.g., "identified hashmap approach after hint" or "Clearly communicated why stacks were the optimal solution without prompting" vs. "did well").

Interviewer Evaluation Form

Candidate Information

- **Candidate Name: Ava Attina**
- **Interviewer Name: Michael DiNapoli**
- **Date: 5/6/2026**
- **Problem Given: Evaluate Reverse Polish Notation**

1. Problem Understanding (0–4) Did

the candidate clearly understand the problem?

0 – Completely misunderstood

1 – Major gaps, needed heavy assistance

2 – Partial understanding, some clarification needed

3 – Mostly clear, minor clarifications

4 – Fully understood, restated clearly

Notes: Shefully understood the problem. She completed it with some minor clarifications. She knew the data structure nd how to work through the problem by identifying how to use conditionals to complete the problem.

2. Communication & Collaboration (0–4)

Did the candidate clearly explain their thinking and work effectively with the

interviewer?

0 – No explanation, unresponsive or defensive
1 – Very unclear, struggled with feedback
2 – Some explanation, inconsistent collaboration
3 – Clear, receptive, reasonably collaborative
4 – Very clear, structured, highly collaborative and adaptive

Notes: yes very clear, structure and highly collaborative and adaptive. Explained why she did the code the way she did it.

3. Implementation & Technical Depth (0–4)

How well did they implement their solution and reason about its correctness and efficiency? *(Coding, testing, complexity, optimization)*

0 – No working solution, no understanding of complexity
1 – Major issues, incorrect or missing complexity reasoning
2 – Partially correct solution, basic or incomplete analysis
3 – Mostly correct, reasonable testing, correct complexity analysis 4 – Clean, correct, well-tested solution with strong optimization and tradeoff discussion

Notes: She knew how to implement the code and how it worked.

4. Team Fit & Working Style (0–4)

Would you want this person on your team based on how they operate under pressure and uncertainty?

0 – Actively defensive, dismissive, or hard to work with
1 – Friction-heavy, resistant to feedback or collaboration

2 – Neutral; neither adds nor detracts
3 – Positive teammate; receptive, steady, easy to work with
4 – Strong team asset; calm under uncertainty, humble, ownership mindset

Notes: Positive and knew what she was doing. I think she would work well on team.

Final Evaluation

Total Score: _16__ / 16

Hiring Recommendation

Strong Hire
Hire
Lean Hire
Lean No Hire
No Hire
Strong No Hire

Final Decision

Summarize your decision in 3–5 sentences. Focus on:

- Key strengths
- Key weaknesses
- Why you made your decision

Use specific examples from the interview to support your decision.

Interviewer Grading Guidelines

- Completion (are all sections filled out)?
  - 40% credit
- Final Decision & Justification
  - 40% credit
- Per section – Notes:
  - 5% credit if the provided notes were valuable (bullets or sentences with specific examples citing your reasoning for the ranking)

Candidate

As the candidate, your goal is to ✨ GET A JOB ✨ (survive a technical interview).

You will:

- Solve the given coding problem
- Aim for an efficient (ideally optimal) solution
- Clearly explain your thought process while working
- Communicate tradeoffs, ideas, and reasoning out loud
- Respond to hints or feedback from the interviewer
- Write and submit
  - A working solution
  - A short writeup explaining the time complexity of your solution and how it solves the problem.

For fairness to our less experienced students, you will have access to our Python cheat sheet during the exercise (though eventually you'll need to be able to take interviews without this!)

You will be graded on the quality of your submitted code and your problem-solving approach. You will **not** be graded in any way from the comments or report submitted by the interviewer. You may code on paper, or in any IDE/text editor that does NOT have AI or autocomplete (examples: Vim, notepad, VsCode without Copilot)

I think the interview went well. I was able to identify the data structure that had to be used and how to implement it. Overall I think it went well but I also think I’ll need to practice more to really get down all of the possible data structures that could be asked during a technical interview.